

Teaching Philosophy:

Version 2

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Teaching Philosophy

As a former crime data analyst, a mentor to interns, a volunteer in elementary school libraries, and a mother of two young children, I have had varied opportunities to instruct, assist, and expose adult professionals and primary students to analytical tools and information resources. Within these groups of learners, there is a diverse array of individuals with differing levels of skills and literacies that I have had the privilege to interact with.

Stemming from the contrasts in the educational settings I have led, the primary component of my teaching philosophy is to foster the curiosity that learners of all ages and backgrounds arrive with. I strive to meet learners where they are by asking questions and gathering details about the informational needs and knowledge base of individual learners. This is key to my philosophy because I believe that to champion curiosity effectively, educators must model curiosity authentically. These genuine interactions with students enable a culture of learning where students feel they can safely return regardless of the progress they've made or the challenges they face. Demonstrating an inquisitive and exploratory attitude as an educator also encourages learners to think critically and propose their own solutions.

While I believe that critical thinking is fueled by curiosity, I also know that learners need access to appropriate tools and resources to successfully analyze, evaluate, and make informed decisions. One reason this needs attention is that the tools and resources that are appropriate can change as time marches on. For instance, 10 years ago, gamification was all the rage and educators were being encouraged to gamify everything so that students could relate to material they would otherwise lose interest in. Currently, social psychologists are questioning whether the push to gamify is as valuable as was once believed. Researchers are studying the effects of gamification on children's brains such as the downregulation of dopamine receptors and the correlation between screen use and anxiety and depression. Educational philosophies are constantly evolving as we learn more about topics that affect

learners. Therefore, another core component of my teaching philosophy is to stay connected to other educators in LIS and other fields by reading scholarly publications, attending relevant conferences and workshops, and interacting with the library community as well as other communities in education. Continually gathering information about best practices, new technologies, and alternative methods and strategies facilitates informed access.

The momentum that is built by communities of learning when access is well informed creates progress. Conscious and strategic learners are produced by these communities and a generative natural intelligence, so to speak, can emerge. Therefore, another important component of my teaching philosophy is to help learners recognize that trajectories are set and maintained through continuous active engagement with learning materials and through collaboration with peers. We are each intrinsically motivated differently, but collaboration affords learners the opportunity to choose how we will participate as individuals toward a larger goal. Engaging in learning spaces creates autonomous leaders, skill builders, relevance seekers, problem solvers, those who are circumspect and make sound judgements, as well as those who support the social aspects of group learning. There is space in the world for input from all these people and it excites me to know that I am learning from each interaction I have with a uniquely situated student. Equally rewarding is the chance to bear witness to the fulfillment learners experience because of their individual efforts and to the progress made through collective action.

Student fulfillment and student progress are not always as easily achieved as one may hope. I appreciate that all learners, at one point or another, will struggle to acquire the knowledge that they seek. It can often feel like there is a maze between not knowing and knowing. Sheryl Crow said it best; every day is a winding road. This challenge, however, exists for both educators and learners and can be remediated through reflective practice. Thinking not only about how to improve my own methods but

also about how to help students correlate feelings of frustration with future success is a fundamental step toward providing students with self-agency and resilience. Ultimately, I think that students and educators want to feel valuable and significant. That vulnerability ties us all together and reminds me to start each day knowing that I may need to listen and I may need to speak but that either way, something will be learned.

Revision Reflection

The key aspects of my teaching philosophy remained the same between versions one and two. However, I added some details about how I plan to accomplish maintaining my philosophy throughout my career, what informs my philosophy, what I hope my philosophy will add to the world, and why my philosophy is important to me. Hopefully, this additional context will help the reader to understand what I can contribute to the profession, the institution, the company, or the community.